National Security Council and State Department officials recognized that these aid delays were causing concern in India about US reliability.[209] With a grim foreign exchange situation, Indian officials were desperate for information on economic assistance and could not understand why Johnson was delaying. At that point, even Bundy was not quite sure what condition the president wanted to attach to food aid. Komer meanwhile highlighted for Johnson the risks of stalling on the military supply front, noting that delaying a response on Indian requests for aircraft would lead Delhi to look even more to Moscow. Johnson, however, wanted to continue to "hold up" military assistance as well.[210]

As the summer progressed, a resigned Johnson declared to Senator Richard Russell (D-GA), "I got to give them something."[211] It was, however, not going to be business as usual. He agreed to let FY1965 military supplies continue, but deferred any commitment for FY1966.[212] Toward the end of July, Johnson also approved a two-month extension of food assistance to India instead of the one- or two-year extension that his advisers had recommended—the beginning of what came to be known as the short-tether policy. Before any bilateral negotiations about long-term aid could take place, however, war broke out between India and Pakistan in August 1965.

The Stakes Made Evident (August–September 1965)

US intelligence estimates in December 1964 and March 1965 had noted that "major hostilities" between India and Pakistan would be unlikely over the next three to four years.[213] The Rann of Kutch clashes cast doubts on those estimates. The war that broke out in late summer proved them inaccurate. The first hint of trouble between India and Pakistan reached Washington on August 8. The US had evidence of Pakistani infiltration across the ceasefire line in Kashmir.[214] By mid-August, Indian troops had crossed the ceasefire line. Then, on September 1, in a "thrust at the Indian jugular," Pakistani regulars crossed the ceasefire line to cut off access from Delhi to the Kashmiri capital.[215]

Despite urging from some of his officials to do something, Johnson's preferred course of action was to "get behind a log and sleep a bit." The stakes did not seem high enough, and he did not think that the US had